Populists' disdain for IOs is further fueled by the constraints these institutions place on their actions. IOs often enforce rules that limit leaders' ability to implement their agendas or govern unilaterally (Vreeland 1999; Drezner 2017). These restrictions can be deeply frustrating for populists, who wish to forcefully assert their sovereignty. When IO mandates conflict with domestic priorities, populists blame these institutions for stifling progress and alienating their constituents. This narrative resonates with populist supporters, who already harbor resentment toward elites and internationalism. As Taggart (2000) puts it, "internationalism and cosmopolitanism are anathema to populists."

This antagonism toward IOs has far-reaching implications for global governance. By rejecting the legitimacy of international norms and institutions, populists challenge the foundations of multilateral cooperation. As they erode public trust in IOs, populist leaders create opportunities for nationalistic policies to flourish, often at the expense of collective action on critical global issues such as climate change, public health, and economic stability.

2.2 Populist Tactics to Undermine IOs

Populists often resent IOs' elite-driven and constraining nature, viewing them as obstacles to their vision of direct representation of "the people." In response, populist leaders frequently seek to undermine IOs' authority and legitimacy. To do so, they draw from a diverse arsenal of rhetorical and material tactics, each designed to disrupt the functioning of these institutions and either weaken their standing on the global stage or operate more in line with populists' agendas.

As we previewed in the opening chapter, populists target IOs by withholding critical resources—such as effort, information, and funding—and engaging in toxic communication strategies that sow discord and erode organizational cohesion. These methods are deliberately crafted to reduce IOs' effectiveness and legitimacy, making it harder for them to carry out their mandates. In this chapter, we delve deeper into these subversive strategies, unpacking how populist leaders deploy them to advance their agendas.